

ANTHRO2A TA Section
Week 2: Symbols, Language, Kinship

Fall 2026
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Wednesdays 1-1:50 and 2-2:50 PM

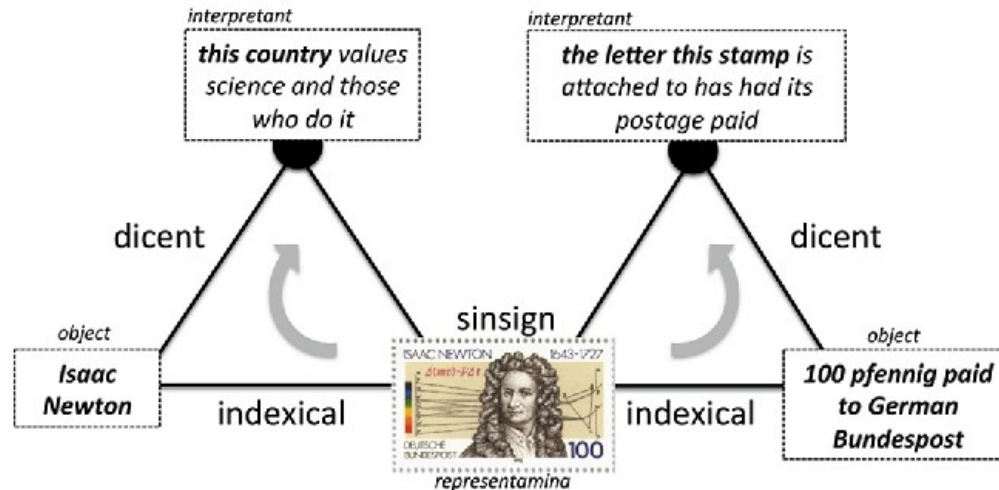
Today we are talking about...

- Symbols
- Language
- Kinship
- To make sure you understand the core concepts of anthropology
- And are ready for the midterm!



Why these concepts?

- Why do anthropologists use these concepts to study others?
- Knowing why will help you to remember them and grasp the bigger picture



Early Colonial Anthropology

- Early European academics studied the effects of industrialization and modernization on European societies
 - The effects of technology, the decline of religion, the growth of the centralized state, modern governance techniques, etc.
- But many non-European societies they encountered didn't have the same things to study
 - Many places did not have European-style states, leaders, division of labor, etc
 - You could not study them through survey data, analysis of political hierarchy, etc

Early Colonial Anthropology

- Early theory: While Western societies used the state to organize society, non-Western societies used more spread-out methods (that also represented “older” forms of society that the West evolved out of):
 - Kinship
 - Symbols and ritual
 - Culture
 - Religion

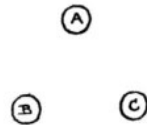


Early Colonial Anthropology

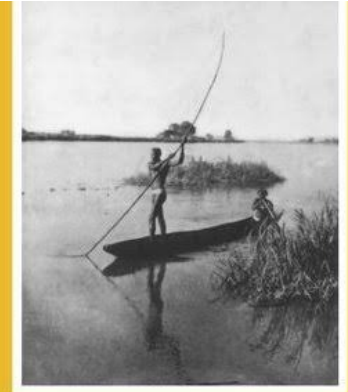
- So if you understood their kinship rules and cultural worldviews, you could understand them better...
 - And control them better

(I.)—My informant placed three large white stones to form the apices of an equilateral triangle. Each stone he said represented one *bwelem*. (Diagram I.) Then, if a woman of A married a man of C, her daughter in C

Diagram I



would marry a man of B, her daughter's daughter in B would marry a man of A again, a man of her M.M.F.'s "line."



THE NUER

*A description of the modes of
livelihood and political institutions
of a Nilotic people*

E. E. EVANS-PRITCHARD

Now?

- Modern American anthropology has critiqued this “colonial”/”imperialist” approach for many reasons
- The concepts and methods from this period are still useful, they just need more nuance
 - Like any science, concepts become more complicated as we know more about the world and start to think about it differently
 - Symbols, culture, and kinship are concepts that can be used to study any society and social phenomenon

Language and Meaning

- People speak different languages, which causes many different questions:
 - Why do we speak different languages?
 - Are all languages the same?
 - Are there ideas that can only be expressed in some languages?
 - Would the world be better if we all spoke the same language?
 - How do we learn a language?
 - How is a language structured, and how can we study it?
- For many reasons, the study of language (linguistics) became an important metaphor for thinking about the study of other aspects of society and culture
 - You could even say that language was an **elaborating symbol** for the social sciences...

Register, Vernacular

- Put simply, if two people can understand each other without issue, they are speaking the same language
- If there is some difference across different geographical regions, they are speaking different dialects
 - Vocabulary difference: elevator vs lift, soda vs pop
 - Pronunciation difference (accent): father
- But if the same person speaks differently because of a different social situation, they are speaking a different register
 - How you talk to/as a cashier is different how you talk to/as a professor

Register, Vernacular

- In modern nations, typically there is one way of speaking that is considered to be the best or most correct
 - This is the standard language
- If you speak something more informal than the standard language, that is the vernacular
- Believing that one language or dialect is better than the other is an act of “linguistic supremacy”
 - This belief is often “naturalized”
 - And a form of “ethnocentrism”
 - And justified through “biological determinism”

Meaning and Symbols

- We notice that different languages can culturally imply different things
 - “I have a **cold**”
 - How would you translate “我上火了” ?
 - “I have **up fire**”
 - How would you translate “Me dio **el mal de puerco** después de comer tamales”?
 - “I have **the evil of the pig**”
- A different word is a different symbol
 - A different symbol points to a different worldview and different culture
 - Understanding this different symbol then, takes more than just a simple translation; it requires an explanation of the relevant cultural worldview



Naturalizing, Encoding, Decode

- When we assume that our symbols are the only ones, or that they make the most sense, that is the act of “naturalizing”
- But if we compare with others, we can realize that there is a system of socially learned symbols at work
- We analyze to find these symbols
- And once identified, decode them to understand more about how the overall culture works

Decoding Proxemics

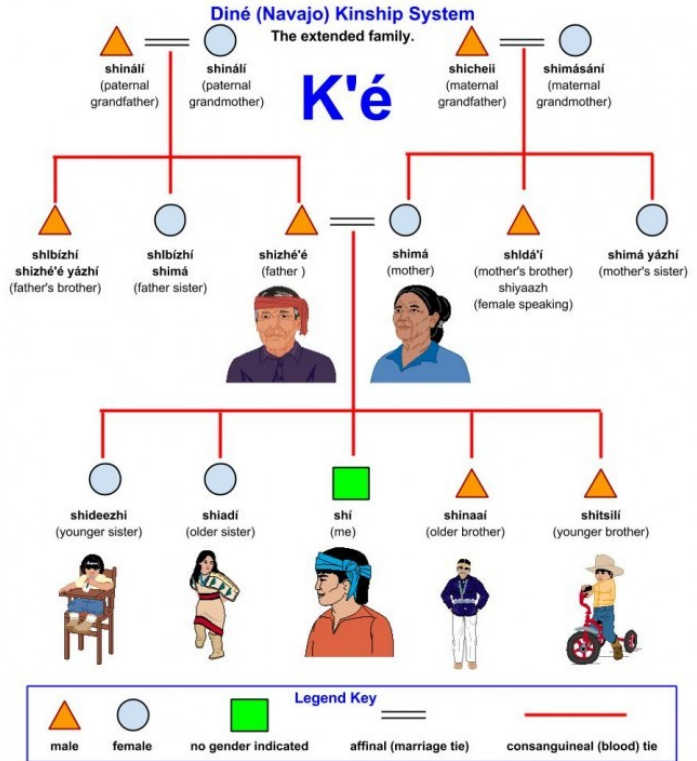


Learning Society and Culture

- Society vs Culture
 - Society: People that have historically in relation with one another
 - Culture: “a set of beliefs, practices, and symbols that are learned and shared. Together, they form an all-encompassing, integrated whole that binds people together and shapes their worldview and lifeways.”
- Acculturation vs Socialization
 - Process of learning culture versus process of learning social rules of relating to others

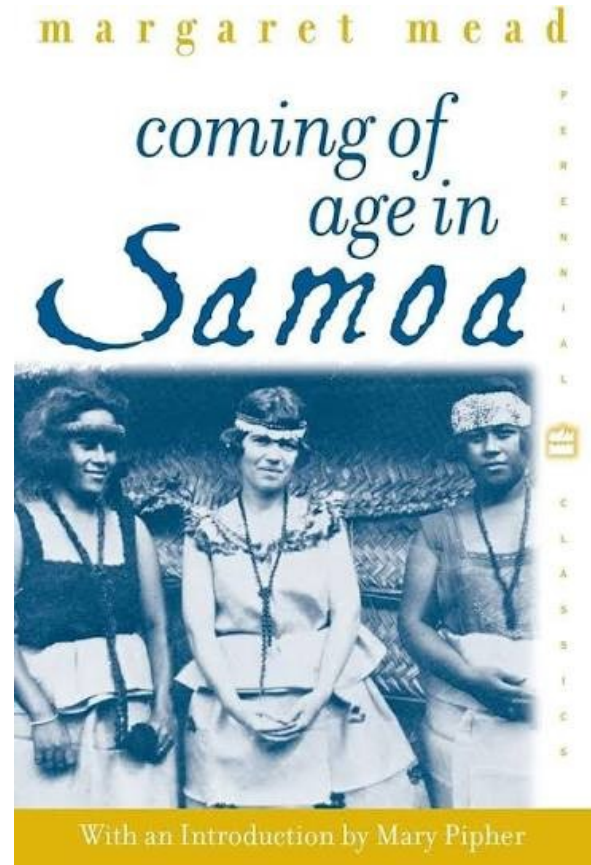
Language and Kinship

- How would you translate:
 - Your mother's older sister?
 - Your father's older sister?
 - *Padrino*
 - Uncle?
 - Unc?
- What is your full name? Where do each of the names come from?
 - Your father? Your mother? Something else?
 - What does your teacher call you? Is it different than what your father calls you? Your brother? Your friend?



Language and Kinship

- If I have a different word for my father's father and my mother's father...
 - Then culturally perhaps I am supposed to have a different relationship with them?
 - So if I use the same word for my mom and my aunts...
 - Then are all my aunts like my mom? Seeing different cultures, symbols, and kinship relations allow us to see how society could be different, instead of accepting what we have now as natural



Symbols and Change

- Seeing different cultures, symbols, and kinship relations allow us to see how society could be different, instead of accepting what we have now as natural
- Remember that symbols do not just have one meaning!
- And that they can change over time
- We have to also study history, context, and connections
- People in a culture may disagree what a symbol means...
 - But there maybe shared cultural practices to figure those meanings out



Assignment #2

- Upload a recipe for a dish onto Canvas that you or your family consider to be “healing”
- Healing can mean anything; to cure an illness, to feel better, etc
- Must have at least 3 ingredients
- Write (no AI!)
 - A list of ingredients
 - Instructions on how to make it
 - The significance of the dish, and why you think its “healing”
 - Context of how to eat it (what to eat it with, how many people eat it, when to eat it, etc)
- We will use this next week to talk more about the concepts on the midterms